



AFTER

At the start of the Civil War, about a quarter of U.S. factory workers were women. Five years later, the proportion had risen to a third.

MODEL WORKING CONDITIONS

By 1860, the **United States' largest industrial complex was Lowell**, Massachusetts, whose textile mills were famous for their "Mill Girls."

The Lowell mills had been **set up as a social experiment to avoid the harsh conditions** of British mill towns. Young, single women from farms and small towns as far away as Maine made up the bulk of the workers. **Employers promised parents that each girl would be provided with room and board** in a supervised dormitory and that church attendance on the one day off was mandatory. The women published their own periodical, *The Lowell Offering*, and had **access to circulating libraries, musical instruments, and traveling lecturers**.

After the war, the Lowell mills became more dependent on French Canadian and European immigrants, until by 1900 nearly half the city's population was foreign-born.

WOMEN TAKING CHARGE

In the South, there were fewer factories, but outside the wealthy planter class, **most white women were accustomed to hard work** on smaller farms, which had few if any slaves. The chief difference the war made was that many women had to **take on the running of farms** or plantations in the absence of their menfolk.